

The Impact of Societal Pressure on the Willingness to Study Medicine Among Medical Students in Dhaka: A Survey-Based Study

Scholar Name: Ayman Rahman

Scholar's Affiliation: SFX Greenherald International School

Mentor: Md Sanaul Haque Shanto

Date of Submission: 10th August 2026

Abstract

Medical education in Bangladesh is heavily governed by societal prestige, cultural norms, and parental expectations. This often leads students to pursue medicine under intense external coercion rather than intrinsic passion. This study investigates the direct impact of socio-familial pressure on post-admission academic satisfaction and career regret among medical students, interns, and graduates in Dhaka, Bangladesh. Understanding this relationship is critical, as forced career alignment contributes to severe psychological strain and burnout among healthcare trainees. A quantitative cross-sectional design was deployed (N=96), utilizing 5-point Likert-scale instruments to quantify socio-familial pressure and academic satisfaction. Non-parametric statistical procedures—including Spearman's rank correlation (r_s), Mann-Whitney U tests, and Kruskal-Wallis H tests—were executed to evaluate primary hypotheses and control for key demographic confounders (gender, age, secondary curriculum background, public versus private medical college status, and academic year progression). Inferential testing revealed an extremely significant positive correlation between socio-familial pressure and academic dissatisfaction ($r_s = 0.59$, $p = 2.8 \times 10^{-10}$), that is, greater the socio-familial pressure, the lower the academic satisfaction. Non-parametric control evaluations showed no statistically significant differences in dissatisfaction ranks across any measured demographic or institutional subgroups ($p > 0.05$), demonstrating that career regret stemming from socio-familial coercion transcends institutional and demographic boundaries. These findings are pivotal for educational policymakers and healthcare administrators in Bangladesh, emphasizing that long-term student fulfillment and mental well-being require structural reforms, including pre-admission career autonomy counseling, non-stigmatized institutional mental health services, and parental awareness initiatives to prioritize student agency over prestige-driven career choice.

Keywords: Socio-familial pressure, Academic satisfaction, Career regret, Career autonomy, Medical education, Doctor, Self-Determination Theory, Non-parametric analysis, Dhaka.

1. Introduction

The selection of a professional career path in South Asia is rarely an isolated personal decision; rather, it represents a collective familial endeavor deeply interwoven with social status, cultural norms, and familial prestige [1]. In Bangladesh, higher education choices are strongly dictated by various external influences, including financial considerations and social conformity [1]. Medical education, in particular, is viewed as a pinnacle of academic achievement that confers immense social respect upon an individual's family [2], [4]. Consequently, the intense drive to fulfill parental aspirations can overshadow a student's personal interests, giving rise to potential mismatches between chosen career paths and personal passion [1], [6].

